

DISCIPLINARY EXPERTISE AND FACULTY CREDENTIALING IN LEADERSHIP STUDIES: ADVANCING A NECESSARY CONVERSATION

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The disciplinary backgrounds of leadership studies educators have considerable influence on the future of the field; however, disciplinary expertise and credentialing have yet to be examined thoroughly in the literature. Decisions pertaining to the preparation and credentialing of leadership educators, particularly among faculty, are a necessary supplement to existing discourse on the standardization of academic programs and the aim and scope of scholarship privileged within the field. While disciplinary boundaries are permeable and fluid, the organizational boundaries defined within institutions based on disciplinary affiliation impose specific expectations and limitations that may artificially constrain interdisciplinary pursuits, including those within leadership studies. The current article presents a conceptualization of how disciplinary expertise and faculty credentialing may shape the future of leadership studies. It is recommended that leadership studies faculty cultivate program-level consensus, demonstrate the integrity of leadership studies curricula, enhance interdisciplinary legitimacy through boundary spanning, determine the future trajectory of leadership studies, and set the course accordingly.

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The leadership enterprise is richly diverse in disciplinary representation (Andenoro et al., 2013; Andenoro & Skendall, 2020). Evidenced by a robust and expanding body of academic literature, as well as formal programs of study at the undergraduate and graduate level, leadership studies has emerged as a distinct field of inquiry and postsecondary specialization (Brungardt et al., 2006; Diallo & Gerhardt, 2017; Friesen, 2018; Gerhardt & Diallo, 2013; Ritch & Mengel, 2009; Watt, 2003). Efforts to synthesize and define a comprehensive research agenda have also helped to formalize and advance the field of study (Andenoro et al., 2013; Andenoro & Skendall, 2020; Jenkins & Dugan, 2013). Within the academy, external standards for accreditation require a clear alignment of disciplinary traditions, programmatic conceptual paradigms, instructional activities, and student learning outcomes (Salto, 2021). Rather than adopting standardization and processes of accreditation, however, leadership studies has thus far relied on guiding questions (Ritch & Mengel, 2009) and general principles (International Leadership Association, 2021). In the absence of standardization, formalized, academic credit-bearing leadership programs may encounter disruption stemming from the accreditation process.

Ritch (2013) asserted that individuals and entities such as accrediting organizations should not be dictating the confines or legitimacy of the field. Instead, individuals involved in the accreditation review process should only be those that have expertise germane to the field. As faculty continue to define the boundaries of leadership and distinct subfields of leadership-focused inquiry are refined, quandaries and possibilities have developed in professional and scholarly spaces. Building upon previous symposia on academic leadership programs and formal program review (Perruci & McManus, 2013) and big questions for leadership education (Whitaker & Arensdorf, 2018), the current article conceptualizes the role disciplinary expertise and faculty credentialing have in shaping leadership studies moving forward. The framing of the discussion is informed by existing discourse documented in the literature and additional contextualization gleaned from related areas of inquiry that have undergone or are experiencing their own progression and formalization.

Academic Disciplines and Fields of Study

Leadership studies' status as a discipline versus a field study is foundational to determinations of requisite credentials for affiliated faculty. Discourse on what constitutes an academic field of study or discipline is neither new nor unique to leadership studies (Brungardt et al., 1997; Colvin, 2003; Kuchinke, 2001; Riggio, 2013). Tight (2020) provided an illustrative comparison critique of the conflicting conclusions of higher education studies as a discipline, field, or area of study, stating, "Though we may think of academic disciplines as well established and monolithic, they are really rather amorphous, fractured and transitory entities waiting for events, discoveries or new interpretations to transform them" (p. 419). Graff (2015) similarly posited disciplines and interdisciplinary fields alike are "historical constructs" (p. 6) that are "perpetually being redefined, reshaped, and recast" (p. 12) in response to competition among units within the neoliberal university.

As the types and scope of professorial roles and organizational structure in academia gained complexity during the late 20th century, attention was given to the delineation, structure, and organization of disciplines, as well as the professionalization of professorial roles contained therein (Braxton & Hargens, 1996; Clark, 1997; Ladd & Lipset, 1975; Light, 1974; Ruscio, 1987). Academic disciplines are defined by consensus among multiple variables, depending on the disciplinary classification applied. The variables range from an overarching paradigm, potential applications versus theoretical work, teaching activities, research patterns and output, and relationship to graduate students and their products (Biglan, 1973b). While multiple classifications exist, the Biglan (1973a) and Lodahl and Gordon (1972) models, which identify dimensions that characterize academic disciplines based on epistemological, ontological, and conceptual agreements and traditions, are referenced with the greatest frequency (Becher, 1987; Becher, 2020).

Whereas disciplines traditionally maintain homogeneity in foundational knowledge, within a field of study, one's focus of inquiry serves as the central unifying characteristic of the community and disciplinary background is variable (Sommer, 2000). Moreover,

disciplines, once established, tend to become institutionalized with the academy with greater assurance of resources allocated by the institution. Fields of study, however, are less resourced and may have decreased sustainability due to shifting contexts, priorities, and developments in the area. For example, Rochester (1986) chronicled the rise and fall of international organization as a field of study. Following a robust growth trajectory post-World War II, the field of study declined in prominence beginning in the 1970s. Scholars of international organization cited declining interest among students, shifts in focus among related disciplines, and changeable research agendas that were overly responsive to current issues as contributing factors to the decline of the field.

Renn (2020) astutely noted that there are advantages of being a low consensus field, namely, “the space for creativity and for valuing more than one kind of knowledge” (p. 922). However, such an advantage is offset by myriad disadvantages associated with low consensus fields, including:

- increased susceptibility of external influences on national research agendas;
- difficulty in becoming established and recognized as an expert;
- potential for acquiescence to historically dominant marginalizing and oppressing methodological approaches in the name of tolerating diverse perspectives;
- difficulty in discerning what is valued among review committees; and
- inadequate clarity in hiring, promotion, and tenure expectations (pp. 922–923).

Risks to the field of leadership studies appear to have been abated by the clear and consistent delineation of leadership from management and administrative sciences. Nevertheless, scholars within fields of study, as well as loosely coupled disciplines, must acknowledge and account for low consensus among professorial ranks about how their field is or will be defined. Leadership studies is referred to as both a discipline and a field of study within the literature, and consensus of its status is inconsistent among senior scholars (Komives & Sowcik, 2020; Sowcik, 2012a, 2012b). Given the continued commitment to interdisciplinarity among

senior leadership scholars, the current article maintains leadership studies as a field of study and inquiry.

FRAMING THE FIELD OF LEADERSHIP STUDIES

Broad recognition of the multiple threads of scholarship and practice within the field of leadership and leadership education (or leadership development depending on context) has informed the codification of leadership studies. How leadership studies is formally designated and recognized, however, has historically varied across contexts (Burns, 1978; Collinson & Grint, 2005; Schriesheim & Neider, 1989; Sternberg, 2008; Sutherland et al., 2020). More recently, globalization has contributed to an increasingly complex environment for leaders who must contend with increasingly complicated, or wicked, problems that have no clear solution and require a collaborative, cross-disciplinary response (Lönngren & Van Poeck, 2021; Weber & Khademian, 2008). In response to increased interest in and demand for leadership development, the field of leadership studies has expanded, welcoming a diverse community of scholars, educators, and developments with varied academic and professional backgrounds that, combined, continue to advance the field.

The literature within leadership studies primarily represents theoretical and applied perspectives from the social sciences (Sowcik & Komives, 2020; Yanzuzzi et al., 2020) and business disciplines (Kalargyrou et al., 2012). While social science and business disciplines inform many of the theoretical foundations of leadership studies, the field has expanded its presence to include disciplinary-specific curricula with specialized areas or subfields of application such as leadership in the public sector, nursing, engineering, and education (Komives & Sowcik, 2020). The modern organization of the higher education enterprise, including its accreditation standards and processes, requires a discussion of who is qualified to teach in leadership studies. Specifically, the examination encompasses credit-bearing courses, which is complicated by the cross-, inter-, and transdisciplinary nature of leadership curricula. For example, leadership scholars and accreditors alike may scrutinize which disciplinary backgrounds appropriately prepare

graduate students to teach general leadership studies courses and question whether the same disciplinary backgrounds also qualify individuals to teach discipline-specific leadership courses (e.g., public leadership, leadership in engineering, nursing leadership, educational leadership, etc.). Similarly, how are the appropriate credentials of an instructor of leadership in a specific disciplinary program determined (e.g., leadership in nursing)? Does a nursing graduate degree equip a would-be instructor to develop and deliver specialized leadership curriculum within their own program? Would these same credentials be appropriate for teaching in an interdisciplinary leadership studies program? The previous questions must be included in the discussion of program standardization.

Further illustrating the reality and importance in the diversity of education and professional preparation is the interconnected role of self, group, and context in both theoretical and practical leadership applications (Kellerman, 2018; Seemiller & Crosby, 2019; Seemiller & Priest, 2017; Wallace et al., 2021). For example, context may represent a single organization, industry/sector/field, or broader sociopolitical environment (e.g., comparative global leadership). Similarly, the concept of self and requisite theoretical foundations is informed by the target population for leadership development (Seemiller & Priest, 2015). Youth leadership, student leadership, community leadership, and nonprofit leadership are examples of commonly recognized, specialized, and contextualized foci within leadership development, education, and scholarship (Jenkins & Owen, 2016). Closer examination reveals further refined specialization including, for example, women in leadership and leadership within historically marginalized populations. A critical review of contemporary, Western, patriarchally dominated leadership scholarship and practice is likewise an important thread in the broad conceptualization of the field of leadership studies.

As thought leaders in the field consider the requisite credentials for teaching in leadership studies, it is important to recall that the founding scholars of leadership studies did not hold terminal degrees in leadership studies. Likewise, current faculty appointments in leadership studies programs represent multiple disciplines (Jenkins et al., 2016). Moreover, leadership scholars and

educators advocate for maintaining the rich diversity of disciplinary backgrounds represented in the field of leadership studies. While there has been a documented proliferation of academic programs in leadership studies at the undergraduate and graduate level (Diallo & Gerhardt, 2017; Gerhardt & Diallo, 2013; Watt, 2003), the interdisciplinary nature of leadership studies suggests the field will continue to welcome leadership scholars, leadership educators, and leadership developers who are produced through a variety of disciplinary degree programs. To suggest only graduates of leadership studies programs are appropriately credentialed to teach would be a gross mischaracterization of the field.

As the field gained cross-disciplinary significance, its expansion and rich intellectual diversity invited continued evaluation of its disciplinary connections (Friesen, 2018) and scrutiny of *unsettled questions* pertaining to the continued professionalization of leadership (Kellerman, 2018, pp. 4–6, emphasis in original). For example, Perruci and McManus (2013) wrestled with the tension of legitimacy granted via accreditation and the inherent limitations of a standardized review of programs in leadership studies. Their prediction that accreditation “would serve only to create deep divisions within the [leadership studies] community” (Perruci & McManus, 2013, p. 53) continues to manifest in practice a decade later. Lindsay and Friesen (2020) concurred and posited that leadership is “inherently multidisciplinary” (p. 79) which, considering Friesen’s (2018) prior assertion that “legitimacy within higher education arises from the power inherent in the disciplines” (p. 50), illustrates the continued angst among leadership scholars and educators within the academy. Leadership studies remains an interdisciplinary field of inquiry and practice, which is appropriate given the vast richness of contributions of multiple knowledge bases. Consequently, faculty affiliated with interdisciplinary academic leadership studies programs carry the burden of proof in terms of the legitimacy of their work among their peers and accrediting bodies.

CONSTRUCTS IN LEADERSHIP STUDIES

Recognizing the need to identify and explicate key terms defining the field, Allen and Roberts (2011) first advocated for the conceptualization of *leadership*

learning, which encompasses *leadership training*, *leadership education*, and *leadership development*. They suggested leadership education and leadership training are “subsets” of leadership development, which they define as “a continuous, systemic process designed to expand the capacities and awareness of individuals, group, and organizations in an effort to meet shared goals and objectives” (Allen & Roberts, 2011, p. 67). Guthrie and Jenkins (2018) provided a similar framework that addresses the multiple ways in which students and educators alike may engage in leadership education and skills development. Andenoro et al. (2013) further clarified leadership education as “the pedagogical practice of facilitating leadership learning in an effort to build human capacity and is informed by leadership theory and research. It values and is inclusive of both curricular and co-curricular educational contexts” (p. 3).

In practice, leadership education and leadership studies are often used interchangeably in discussion of

the field of inquiry; however, the present article privileges *leadership studies* as it is inclusive of *leadership education*. Bearing this ambiguity in mind, Figure 1 presents interrelated conceptualizations, or constructs, with key terms and definitions to further illustrate their distinctions and areas of intersection. In Kellerman’s (2018) call for the professionalization of leadership, she posited leadership learning must include elements of leadership *education*, leadership *training*, and leadership *development* (p. 152, emphasis in original), further substantiating the necessity of a comprehensive conceptualization of leadership studies.

Professional Identities, Credentialing, and the Influence of Accreditation

PROFESSIONAL IDENTITIES

Priest and Jenkins (2019) suggested that, like constructs, individual professional identities within leadership studies are fluid and reflective of one’s

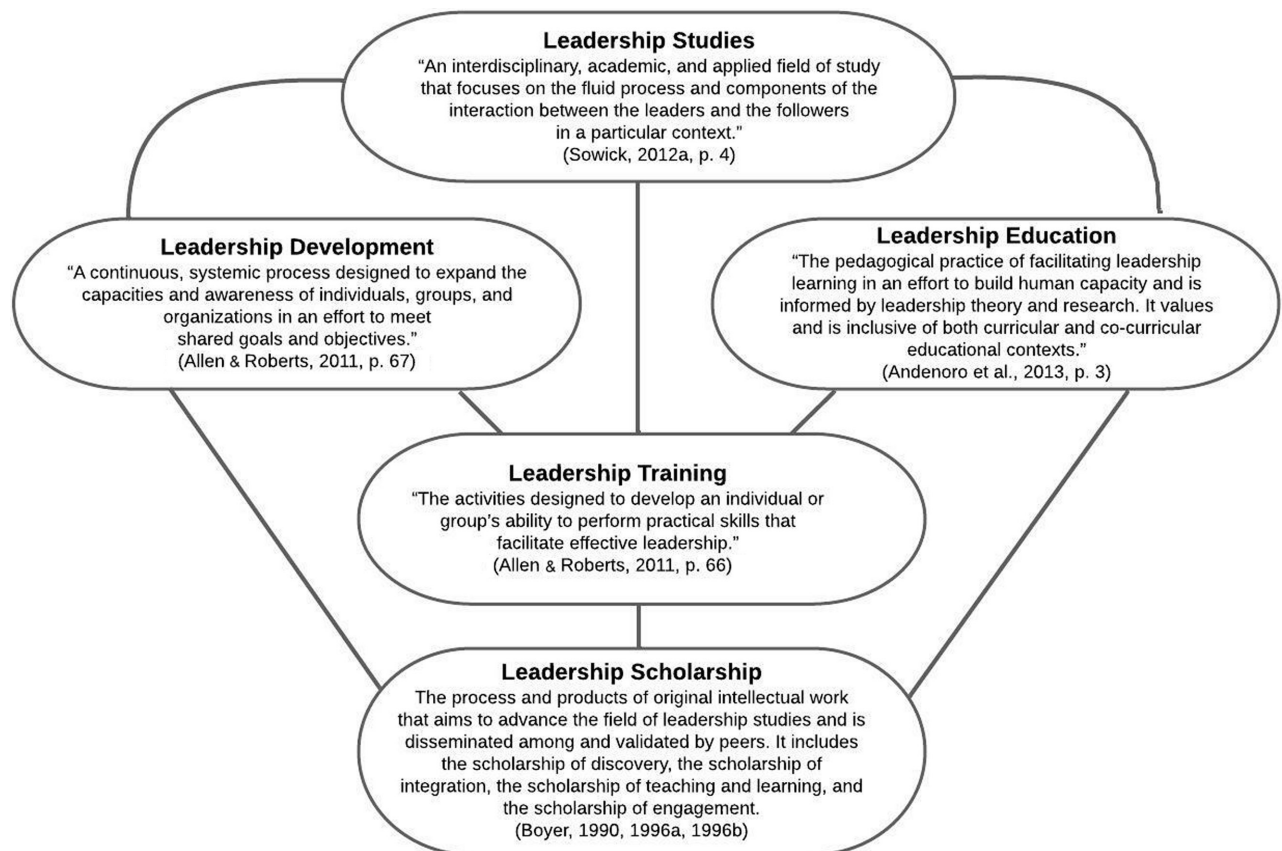


Figure 1 Schema of Interrelated Professional Domain Constructs in Leadership Studies (Allen & Roberts, 2011; Boyer, 1990, 1996a, 1996b)

foundational training, pedagogical priorities, scholarly commitments, and context. Broadly envisioned, the *leadership industry* (Kellerman, 2013, 2018) comprises a wide spectrum of professional identities with varying degrees of emphasis on research and practice and the integration of the two. Consensus on the various professional identities within leadership studies enables the examination of academic preparation and professional pathways (Barbour & Lammers, 2015). Sowcik's (2012a) conceptualization of *leadership studies* as an academic and applied field of study accommodates the multiple related professional identities within higher education and a noteworthy portion of scholarly practitioners beyond the academy.

Due to the continued professionalization/formalization of leadership subfields (Gunter & Ribbins, 2002), it is productive to first clarify the disparate professional identities associated with leadership studies. Within higher education, there are three predominant categories of leadership-focused professional identities: leadership scholars, leadership developers, and leadership educators. Importantly, these identities are not mutually exclusive, and there is no implied or suggested hierarchy or differential value associated with each identity. On the contrary, individuals may find they participate in activities

associated with each type. Intellectual efforts and contributions, however, typically align with a specific category of leadership-focused professional identity. Figure 2 provides clarification through an identity construct typology. Notably, the figure denotes the overlap and interplay between and across the three constructs, signifying the necessary combination of identities within leadership studies curricula. The Typology of Professional Identity Constructs in Leadership Studies builds upon previous efforts by Priest and Jenkins (2019), Darling-Hammond and Bransford (2005), Darling-Hammond (2006), and Jenkins et al. (2016) whose work is reflected in the Framework for Leadership Educator Professional Development (Priest & Jenkins, 2019). The typology presented herein seeks to further elucidate the current dominant professional identities within the field and may serve as a useful heuristic for graduate students and early career professionals as well as individuals interested in clarifying or repositioning their professional identity and/or contributions.

THE LEADERSHIP SCHOLAR

Within the academy there are leadership scholars—academicians, researchers, philosophers—whose relationship to leadership as a field pertains, at least in



Figure 2 Typology of Professional Identity Constructs in Leadership Studies

part, to systematic and empirical inquiry related to leadership theory, concepts, and practice. Regardless of the type of scholar, each is committed to advancing research agendas in order to better understand, critique, develop, and apply leadership in practice. Leadership scholars' courses may or may not seek to explicitly develop individual leadership capacity through competency development and may instead focus on the intellectual exploration and synthesis of leadership topics. Depending on the scholars' disciplinary foundations and pedagogical considerations, the curriculum they deliver may not provide skills training (Crawford et al., 2002). Scholars may teach in an interdisciplinary unit, such as leadership studies, or be affiliated with a traditional discipline-specific department (Jenkins & Owen, 2016). Similarly, their leadership-related research may contribute to interdisciplinary leadership studies literature or a discipline-specific literature base. Both leadership educators and leadership developers may also identify as leadership scholars, often claiming their identity as scholar-practitioners.

THE LEADERSHIP EDUCATOR

Unlike leadership scholars, leadership educators may not have an interest in conducting research. Similarly, research may not be a function of their current professional role. Instead, their emphasis is leadership education, which bridges the intellectual inquiry of leadership theory and practical skill development (Priest & Jenkins, 2019). Competency development is an essential outcome for leadership educators, as is the connection to leadership theory and empirical research within their curriculum, whether curricular or cocurricular. Importantly, leadership educators may deliver credit and noncredit bearing learning opportunities. For example, a leadership educator may serve as an instructor of record for a credit-bearing course or as a facilitator of cocurricular programming. Leadership educators may serve in full-time and part-time faculty positions, as student affairs professionals, or as members of an extension, outreach, or engagement unit and predominantly direct their effort toward student leadership development (Seemiller & Murray, 2013).

THE LEADERSHIP DEVELOPER

Leadership developers are typically unaffiliated with credit-bearing academic programs, though they may teach an occasional course. Instead, their focus is leadership and organizational development through professional learning (Leskiw & Singh, 2007). Their contributions emphasize practitioner-oriented content with a variable emphasis on empirical research and literature on leadership (Dopson et al., 2019). Such individuals are likely affiliated with a centralized learning and development unit for faculty and/or staff, such as a center for university learning, a center for excellence in teaching, or a focused subunit of a human resources department. The work of leadership developers is informed by a combination of theory and practices in adult learning, leadership studies, organizational studies, and management (Petrie, 2011). Similar to leadership educators, leadership developers are dealing with the proliferation of their field and shifts in the leadership landscape writ large as they strategize for future positioning and impact (Moldoveanu & Narayandas, 2019).

Leadership scholars, leadership educators, and leadership developers engage in categorically different, yet complimentary work. They provide deliverables for differentiated audiences, and each requires distinct combinations of academic and professional preparation; however, they each constitute an essential area of expertise within leadership studies. Additionally, comparable levels of graduate study are found within each identity (e.g., scholars, educators, and development may each hold terminal degrees in a related discipline). Because all three professional identities are represented in the classroom as *leadership studies faculty*, it is necessary to explore the degree of inclusion current faculty credentialing practices provide and how faculty and administrators determine adequate preparation for credit-bearing course assignments, particularly among part-time or adjunct faculty who may have less socialization within the field (Jenkins & Owen, 2016).

PREPARATION AND PROFESSIONAL CREDENTIALS

The effort to build consensus on the preparation and credentialing of professionals in leadership studies remains

fraught with deeply held disciplinary biases, blind spots, and self-serving advocacy (Alvesson, 2019; Boyd et al., 2019; Friesen, 2018; Jenkins & Owen, 2016; Lindsay & Friesen, 2020; Whitaker & Arensdorf, 2018). The field's challenge is perpetuated by the inherent interdisciplinarity of leadership studies. Guthrie and Jenkins (2018) reiterated that leadership studies educators come from different disciplinary lenses, contexts, and experiences. As a result of variations, Alvesson (2019) suggested "[leadership studies] is broadly seen as an intellectually weak field—besmirched by elitism, ideology and reductionism" (p. 39) rather than an integrated product of rich interdisciplinarity.

In addition to criticism and questions of disciplinary legitimacy, faculty must also grapple with the potential fluidity (ambiguity) of their placement in organizational structures, particularly when positioned in a hybrid professionalized role (Seemiller & Priest, 2015). For example, leadership educators may have a faculty appointment while also serving in an administrative or student affairs capacity. Subsequently, their dual or third space roles may have competing priorities (Watermeyer, 2015; Whitchurch, 2012). Therefore, discourse on faculty credentialing for leadership studies must consider the disciplinary origins and future trajectory of the field as well as the external influences of accrediting bodies.

Likewise, disciplinary preparation and credentialing have emerged as criteria for the legitimacy and quality of leadership programming, including credit-bearing, cocurricular, and professional curricula. Lindsay and Friesen (2020) suggested the contributions of leadership educators and scholars transcend traditional disciplinary boundaries, yet the very institutions intended to support the field present structural barriers to advancement (e.g., territorialism, prestige, and tenure and promotion systems). Whether structural barriers organically emerge or are contrived by faculty, their impact on scholarship, academic programs, and organization infrastructure affirms the need to review disciplinary norms and boundaries (Becher, 2020).

EXTERNAL INFLUENCE OF ACCREDITING BODIES

External accrediting bodies have a surprising degree of influence on academic programs, particularly

considering members of the review team may have little to no disciplinary expertise within the academic programs they are charged to evaluate (Krause, 2022; Stura et al., 2019). Sowcik et al. (2012) forewarned of "who is privileged by formalized review processes and who is disenfranchised" (p. 68) and how equity is maintained among leadership studies faculty. Still, accreditation may intervene where the field has thus far failed. For example, Kellerman (2018) critiqued the current landscape of credentialing in leadership studies:

We can presume that the small minority of those who teach leadership studies, who are, that is, academics, are at least modestly qualified as experts and educators. But many if not most academics have no special experience or expertise that qualifies them to teach *how to lead*—as opposed to teaching *about leadership*. They have been educated and trained in leadership studies, not in leadership development. Moreover, large numbers of practitioners professing to provide leadership education, training, and development are located outside academy. This means that they are not required to jump through even a single professional hoop. The truth is that anyone can claim to be an expert on leadership, and anyone can claim to know how to teach how to lead. No demonstrable experience required. No demonstrable expertise required. No demonstrable credential required. (p. 5, emphasis in original)

While Kellerman's charged argument is intended to illicit response within the ranks, it fails to recognize existing accreditation bodies have a significant degree of influence on who teaches in leadership studies. Sowcik et al. (2012) posited accreditation, under optimal conditions, has a positive impact on programs, yet concerns remain. For example, accreditors are authorized to determine if a faculty member's teaching credentials are sufficient, regardless of previous determinations made by department faculty and hiring administrators. Peer review, including accreditation, helps to ensure quality and maintain integrity in the academic enterprise, but it can also become bureaucratic and restrictive.

There is greater flexibility in the required qualifications of professional roles and contributions beyond

credit-bearing leadership studies courses. Instructors of record for credit-bearing courses, however, must meet the minimum requirements specified by higher education accrediting bodies (Boyd et al., 2019). For example, whereas the guidance provided by the Council for the Advancement of Standards in Higher Education addresses best practices and benchmarks intended to guide program improvement (Komives & Sowcik, 2020), higher education accreditation agencies inform institutional trajectory and viability due to the primary role of accreditation in the allocation of federal and state education funding (Romanowski, 2022a, 2022b; Sowcik et al., 2012). Hence, determinations made by external accrediting bodies are remarkably influential for internal decision-making, especially in the absence of local-level consensus and justification.

Institutions must document alignment between faculty credentials and courses faculty are qualified to teach by a universal set of program-specific numerical identifiers—The Classification of Instructional Programs (CIP) (National Center for Education Statistics, 2020). For example, the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Commission on Colleges outlines specific expectations for faculty credentialing that justify instructors for each course they are assigned. Such documentation may include standard academic credentials alone (e.g., terminal degrees) or a combination of degrees and professional experience. Essentially, the institution must justify why faculty are qualified to teach their assigned courses (Southern Association of Colleges and Schools Commission on Colleges, 2019). Unfortunately, the interpretation of qualifications becomes a subjective process rife with inconsistency and individual bias, leading to inequitable outcomes.

The *teaching discipline* is therefore an essential consideration for recruiting faculty and determining course assignments that align with instructors' areas of expertise, as evidenced by their advanced degrees, certifications, and scholarly products. Moreover, the extent to which the faculty member's expertise is germane to course topics is of concern. Consequently, accreditation standards for faculty credentialing and CIP codes are important considerations

for the current discussion of leadership studies as a field of study. Both external variables impact: (a) hiring decisions, (b) curriculum development, and (c) attempts to frame and affirm the explicit and implicit boundaries of leadership studies, all of which directly influence the future of the field. Therefore, faculty in leadership studies are behooved to establish local-level consensus regarding appropriate credentials for teaching courses in their program.

Implications for Leadership Studies

Formal accreditation review of academic programs, including leadership studies, is intended to provide measures of quality assurance. Unfortunately, existing accreditation standards and external review processes are influenced by disciplinary biases and prejudice against innovative, future-oriented interdisciplinary fields of study. For example, reviewers whose expertise may not be germane to the field are nonetheless empowered to document any perceived misalignment of teaching credentials and assigned courses in leadership studies, subsequently impacting full-time, part-time, and adjunct leadership studies faculty.

The scenario is cautionary, yet plausible, and is shared with the intent of urging serious consideration of which credentials are appropriate for faculty in a program. The disruption to faculty careers, leadership studies programs, and the students they serve may be avoided by more substantive discourse, consensus, and documentation of alignment between curricula and the leadership studies faculty credentials. Therefore, faculty in leadership studies are urged to consider the following implications informed by the literature and faculty experiences. Specifically, leadership studies faculty must attend to the need for program-level consensus, maintain the integrity of leadership studies curricula, advance the legitimacy of interdisciplinary spaces through their work, and determine the future trajectory of the field.

CULTIVATION OF PROGRAM-LEVEL CONSENSUS

In a field of study that is informed by multiple, interconnected disciplines, the process of standardization is a significant undertaking warranting meticulous

consideration of which disciplinary roots, epistemological paradigms, and bodies of literature comprise the developing literary canon for the field. Likewise, an intentional, inclusive decision-making strategy that encourages broad and diverse participation should be utilized (Gallos, 2009). Concurrently, efforts to support inclusivity should not be adopted at the expense of developing a cohesive statement of purpose and principles. However broadly envisioned, the principles must accommodate the rich intellectual diversity of the field. Efforts to be both an inclusive, yet standardized field will result in constant tension. However, tension is a critical aspect of advancing the field. Despite an occasional call for leadership curriculum to return to disciplinary departments (Alvesson, 2019), the field remains richly diverse in represented knowledge bases. Consequently, program-level conceptual frameworks are an essential consideration (Kellerman, 2018; Klein, 1990; Owen, 2015; Sowcik, 2012a).

Leadership studies programs will vary depending on the institution's mission and priorities, the sponsoring academic home, and the students served. There are common elements, however, that are expected in every program regardless of its design and intent. The International Leadership Association's (2009) *Guiding Questions: Guidelines for Leadership Education Programs* and subsequent Inter-association Leadership Education Collaborative's (ILEC's) *Priorities and Critical Considerations for Leadership Education* (ILEC, 2019) suggest programs need clarity and consensus regarding the conceptual framework, program content, teaching modalities, and program assessment. Sowcik et al. (2012) emphasized the program's conceptual framework as the foundation for determining all subsequent programmatic decisions, which included faculty credentials. Notably, faculty credentialing is determined at the course level, thereby allowing faculty to determine which credentials are appropriate for specific content.

Core components of leadership learning, and therefore leadership studies programs, include leadership education, leadership training, leadership development, consciousness of context, assumption of assessment, prioritization of character (ethics), and the presumption that learning to lead as a process must be comprehensive (Guthrie & Jenkins, 2018; Kellerman, 2018).

Graduate-level credentialing for leadership education and leadership development differs; however, both are essential for a comprehensive program. Hence, careful attention must be given to curricula design, including the most suitable content expertise of the corresponding faculty. Furthermore, consensus among program faculty on what constitutes key aspects is essential for ensuring adequate alignment between faculty credentials and teaching assignments.

DEMONSTRATE INTEGRITY OF LEADERSHIP STUDIES CURRICULA

Concern regarding the quality and integrity of academic leadership studies programs remains a consistent theme in the literature (Brungardt et al., 2006; Harvey & Jenkins, 2014; Klenke, 1993; Malakyan, 2019; Rosch et al., 2023; Watt, 2003). Alvesson (2019) warned that leadership studies curriculum and programming can become easily diluted for economic gain. As institutions compete for resources, faculty encounter pressure from senior administrators to expand offerings without regard to best practices in leadership learning design and delivery. Maintaining a corps of competent and credentialed faculty is essential for countering increased pressure on programs and is core to the integrity of leadership studies curricula.

When curriculum is developed and approved, faculty members proposing the curriculum are expected to have a level of expertise in their discipline or field of study. Such expertise is typically verified via a graduate degree that recognizes completion of a postsecondary program of study in that field. When degrees are conferred, support and approval of faculty members, who themselves are products of systems of standardized and organized inquiry comprising a discipline or field of study, is denoted. The academic tradition of degree conferral symbolizes higher education's ongoing commitment to quality in education and the assurance of integrity undergirding the enterprise.

Amid the rise and market expansion of predatory institutions, the significance of higher education institutions' commitment to quality and integrity has become ever more consequential. As such, faculty participation in and support of external review in the form

of accreditation at the program and institutional levels is as equally important and valuable as the rigorous, peer-review, scholarly pursuits in which faculty routinely engage. While standards of excellence are warranted and should be pursued, careful critique of the standard's purpose, design, execution, and effectiveness must be considered during the development and refinement process.

ENHANCE INTERDISCIPLINARY LEGITIMACY THROUGH BOUNDARY SPANNING

The field of leadership studies is a prime example of the potential within emergent spaces of interdisciplinary dialogue. Despite continuous efforts to professionalize the field, there is ample opportunity remaining for faculty to further legitimize leadership studies as a high-quality, significant, and relevant area of interdisciplinary study. Collinson and Grint (2005) made similar observations regarding leadership research noting that, in its current state, it lacks commonality and can be fragmented, trivial, and superficial. They suggested engagement among researchers could lead to increased consensus, resulting in higher quality and more impactful research.

Collinson and Grint's (2005) commentary on the lack of professional community among academic leadership researchers similarly applies to leadership studies faculty who limit their engagement to traditional disciplinary communities. The Association of Leadership Educators (ALE) and the International Leadership Association (ILA) provide a valuable cross-disciplinary space and resources to support leadership studies faculty. Moreover, members of ALE and ILA spanned boundaries to form a combined community of practice, the ILEC, which produced the Priorities and Critical Considerations for Leadership Education (ILEC, 2019) for the express purpose of addressing how professional associations can enhance boundary spanning within their membership (Endersby et al., 2019). Disciplinary boundary spanning is a missing component that leadership faculty may engage in to steward local-level communities of practice (Endersby et al., 2019). Sommer (2000) stated, "crossing boundaries stimulates the development of new languages and terminology, intermedi-

ate communities, new institutional forms, and new categories of knowledge" (p. 1), which is precisely the goal of cross- and interdisciplinary dialogue and a key contribution of leadership studies. Continuous dialogue across disciplines (Riggio & Harvey, 2011) requires engagement among leadership scholars, educators, and developers who might otherwise operate in silos within their institutions.

Friesen (2018) similarly called for an integration, or nexus, of contributions representing a variety of disciplines and encouraged faculty to apply collaborative leadership within their institutions. Within the boundary spanning literature, the *nexus effect* describes the combined outcomes achieved by leaders who span boundaries which are more impactful than the sum of independent contributions (Yip et al., 2008). Faculty who are effective boundary spanners are problem-solvers (e.g., engage in reflective practice and reflexivity for continuous improvement), integrated experts (e.g., teaching, research, and practice inform one another), and relational facilitators (e.g., readily collaborate and mediate between individuals and communities outside of their comfort zone) (Purcell et al., 2021). Clifford and Petrescu (2012) warned that cross-disciplinary and cross-unit collaborations can be challenging and resource intensive. Nevertheless, spanning disciplinary boundaries is an opportunity for faculty to respond to Kellerman's (2018) critique of leadership studies faculty qualifications by demonstrating their expertise *about* leadership as well as *how* to lead, in this case, within and beyond academic communities. In short, leadership faculty must practice what they profess.

DETERMINE THE FUTURE TRAJECTORY OF LEADERSHIP STUDIES AND SET THE COURSE

The leadership landscape within and beyond higher education is shifting, so it is an opportune moment to revisit core values as a field and chart the course forward. Subsequent change is timely as the COVID-19 pandemic spurred a renewed interest in leadership theory and practice (Purcell et al., 2022), thereby providing a pivotal moment for repositioning leadership scholarship and leadership studies at the forefront of society. Building consensus around the "new normal" is a significant moment for leadership scholars to demonstrate

their expertise, relevance, and legitimacy (Butler et al., 2015; Harris & Santilli, 2021). The wicked problems of the 21st century cannot be solved within disciplinary silos (Kramer et al., 2019; Paquin et al., 2017; Satterwhite et al., 2020; Sternberg, 2008; Wren, 2009). To the contrary, interdisciplinarity in its multiple manifestations (e.g., multi-, cross-, inter-, and transdisciplinary inquiries) will provide a pathway forward.

In discussing shifting paradigms and evolving knowledge among leadership educators, Satterwhite et al. (2020) spoke to the necessity of transgressing and disrupting boundaries that deter the collaborative innovation required to navigate complexity, suggesting that effective leaders will facilitate learning and development across units, organizations, and communities. The path forward is interdisciplinary, which is evidenced by the increasing prevalence of innovative interdisciplinary programs, centers, and institutes (Gray, 2008; Hoffman & Axson, 2017). Federal grants, private donors, and academic journals are likewise seeking out interdisciplinary scholars (National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine, 2018). It is time for leadership studies faculty to apply our expertise: to lead.

Speaking on the volatility and incessant change experienced in modern leadership, Burns (2002) claimed that leadership educators must recognize the new demands of leaders and develop curricula and programming accordingly. Burns called for learning and development built upon the premise of unpredictable and turbulent environments that requires leaders to develop adaptive responses. Burns' predictions now have even greater relevancy and urgency. Leadership studies faculty must demonstrate their current legitimacy while simultaneously preparing for an unknown future.

The COVID-19 pandemic disrupted the status quo, offering a moment of punctuated equilibrium, a *Covid Shift* (Purcell et al., 2022), through which transformative individual, organizational, and societal growth may readily occur. Concurrently, the dual pandemic of systemic racism calls for expedited change and accountability (Hudson et al., 2022; Jones, 2021; Pradies et al., 2021). The coincidence of societal pandemics calls for action from all leadership scholars, educators, and developers (Beytekin, 2021; Dobni et al., 2021; Lowe & Gardner,

2000; Osborn et al., 2002). Specifically, the lingering "imprecision" (Wallace et al., 2021, p. 1) in leadership studies programs, foremost of which is consensus on faculty credentials, requires immediate attention.

Conclusion

The future of the field requires leadership scholars to address the continued lack of consensus in its theoretical cannon, programmatic standards, and ambiguity surrounding, which disciplinary backgrounds are in fact relevant and related. Readers are encouraged to engage in program-level consensus-building that will honor the intellectual diversity of the field's senior and emerging scholars while plotting a trajectory that will refine the boundaries of the leadership studies and legitimize its contributions within the academy. The timing for future-oriented development and strategy among leadership studies programs is optimal; paradigms are shifting worldwide postpandemic. Leadership scholars and professionals are poised to respond to this opportunity to inform public discourse and policy development and would be remiss to discount the current moment as a critical inflection point for transformation and legitimacy. *Wicked* problems are expanding in complexity and volume—society needs critical thinkers and leaders whose academic training prepares them to collaborate across disciplinary and professional boundaries. The essential criterion of effective leadership is best taught by educators who themselves have demonstrated capacity for such boundary spanning. Leaders in the field have the responsibility to model the behaviors that espouse and are necessary for transformational leadership. The field of leadership studies is poised for scholars and professionals to collectively refine the disciplinary boundaries of the field and galvanize its future advancement and impact.

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